

Stages of Listening

The Receiving Stage

The first stage of the listening process is the receiving stage, which involves hearing and attending. Hearing is the physiological process of registering sound waves as they hit the eardrum. As obvious as it may seem, to effectively gather information through listening, we must first be able to physically hear what we're listening to. If we have a hearing impairment, our listening ability will be challenged. Excessive noise in the environment can create obstacles to receiving audible sound waves.

Paired with hearing, attending is the other half of the receiving stage in the listening process. Attending is the process of accurately identifying and interpreting particular sounds we hear as words. The sounds we hear have no meaning until we give them their meaning in context. Listening is an active process that constructs meaning from verbal and nonverbal messages.

Attending also involves discerning human speech, also known as speech segmentation. Identifying auditory stimuli as speech but not being able to break those speech sounds down into sentences and words would be a failure of the listening process.

The Understanding Stage

The understanding stage is when the listener determines the context and meanings of the words heard through decoding. Understanding or comprehension occurs when the listener's determination of the context and meanings of the words match the speaker's message. One tactic for better understanding a speaker's meaning is to ask questions to fill in any holes you may have in the mental reconstruction of the speaker's message.

The Evaluating Stage

This stage of the listening process is when the listener assesses the information they received qualitatively and quantitatively. Evaluating allows the listener to form an opinion of what they heard and, if necessary, to begin developing a response.

The evaluating stage occurs most effectively once the listener fully understands what the speaker is trying to say. Having a clear understanding of a speaker's message allows a listener to evaluate that message without getting bogged down in ambiguities or spending unnecessary time and energy addressing points that may be tangential or otherwise nonessential.

The Remembering Stage

In the listening process, the remembering stage occurs as the listener categorises and retains the information they have gathered from the speaker for future access. Suppose the listener has been attending, understanding, and evaluating. In that case, the result will likely be stored memory—allowing the listener to record information about people, objects, and events for later recall. This happens both during and after the speaker's delivery.

The Responding Stage

The responding stage is the stage of the listening process in which the listener provides verbal and nonverbal reactions based on short- or long-term memory.

Nonverbal responses such as nodding or eye contact allow the listener to communicate their level of interest without interrupting the speaker, thereby preserving the speaker/listener roles. When a listener responds verbally to what they hear and remember—for example, with a question or a comment—the speaker/listener roles are reversed, at least momentarily.